DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

What Does the Face Reveal About the Soul?

Daat Tevunot §82-87

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §82-87
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 9 February 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Getting our bearings

The class began at §82, the start of the fourth part of section 4. The Rabbi first read note 74 in the English edition, which summarises the section so far, and set out the framework of the book:

- **Section 1:** the introduction, what we want from the book.
- **Section 2:** why God created the world.
- **Section 3:** Yihud Hashem, which begins in concealment and is the one attribute that can be revealed.
- **Section 4, part 1:** the nature of body and soul. The body is for this world and the soul for the next; in this world the soul must overpower the body, and in the next the body will be subservient to the soul.
- **Part 2:** body and soul come from concealment and illumination. When the body prevails concealment increases; when the soul prevails illumination increases.
- **Part 3:** every detail of body and soul precisely represents these two attributes: the body's many organs reflect concealment, the soul's oneness reflects God's oneness.
- **Part 4 (now):** how the balance between illumination and concealment shapes the body and soul in the main epochs of time: the six thousand years, the seventh millennium, and the stages of reward after it. This will bring the section to its end.

§82-84: principles, not details

Before starting, the Sekhel says that God needed many laws and creations to provide for man in all these periods. As Tehillim says, "How great are Your works". There are many details, but he will give only the principles.

The Rabbi called this one of the Ramhal's great principles, which he stated at the very start of Derech Hashem: details are hard to remember and principles are easy, so in every discipline in life one should go after the principles. The Ramhal adds that Hazal said the same about words of Torah.

Three things to understand

The Sekhel then sets out what we need to know. We have seen two attributes, concealment and illumination, which are the roots of body and soul. We must understand:

1. **Each one on its own**, with its principles and some details: how concealment is reflected in the body and illumination in the soul.
2. **How they work together** to run the world. The Rabbi reminded the group of the irony they discussed at length: the concealment is the visible one, and the world looks that way, while the illumination is hidden in the background, steering the world towards the tikkun haklali.
3. **The consequences** born of their interaction, depending on which one prevails, in each of the different epochs.

The first two have already been explained. The rest of this part will deal with the third, mostly at the level of the whole world, though the last epoch will speak more about the individual.

§85: where are the consequences seen in man?

The Neshamah says: I understand that God wanted to display His two attributes in man, and does so through body and soul. I also understand how their interaction is reflected in man, in the way body and soul work together and sometimes struggle. But you said there is a third element, the consequences of the interaction. Where do we see that reflected in a human being?

Before the answer was read, a participant suggested an example: a person whose body is half paralysed, or someone with a weak heart, as though the soul were not illuminating that part. The Rabbi said that is precisely where the Ramhal goes next.

§86: ziv hapanim, the radiance of the face

The Sekhel answers. Look carefully at how a person is built. Besides the body itself, its limbs and organs, and besides the soul that gives it life, there is something produced by their interaction: the ziv hapanim, the radiance of a person's face.

The Rabbi stressed that this does not mean the physical face, which is part of the body. It is the countenance, the glow, which distinguishes the living from the dead. When a person is ill his radiance is poor, because the soul is not giving the body its full energy, and that shows on the face.

A participant asked why God would let the soul withhold energy until a person falls sick. The Rabbi said that is a different question, which they would not go into now; the point here is only the reflection.

"Your soul can be seen through your face." When a person is happy his face smiles; when he is angry it darkens. These are all testimony to what is in the chambers of the heart. The countenance is not of the soul alone, since it shows on the face, nor of the body alone, since without the soul the body is nothing. It is the product of their interaction, and that is the third element reflected in man.

God's "appearance" in the prophets

The Ramhal adds that the prophets describe God with human images to give us some understanding. In the previous week's parashah, God appears at the Red Sea like a mighty warrior going out to battle. Elsewhere He appears like an old man full of mercy. The Rabbi explained that through such images the prophets show God's modes: the merciful elder reflects one aspect and the warrior another. And just as a human face shows the combination of body and soul, these images show what is produced by the combination of God's attributes.

§87: on to the epochs

The Neshamah says: you have explained the reflection well; now speak about the actual stages in the different epochs and how the interactions play out there. That begins in §88 and will take us to the end of the section.

The Rabbi summed up the three stages once more. First, body and soul themselves, reflecting concealment and illumination. Second, their combination, reflecting how God combines illumination and concealment in running the world. Third, the result, which in man is the radiance of the face. What the results of God's conduct are in this world and the next will be the topic of the coming classes.

Summary

- Part 4 of section 4 will describe body and soul, illumination and concealment, across the epochs: the six thousand years, the seventh millennium, and the world of reward.
- The Ramhal gives principles, not details, a rule he stated at the start of Derech Hashem.
- There are three things to understand: each attribute alone, their interaction, and its consequences.
- In man, the consequence of the interaction of body and soul is the ziv hapanim, the radiance of the face, which shows health, mood and what is in the heart.
- The prophets' images of God, as a warrior or as a merciful elder, likewise show His modes and their combination.

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